Act 170 Merger Committee Meeting #1

Building a Shared Foundation for Our Work

Chittenden Central Region — Burlington | South Burlington | Winooski

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October 20, 2026 | 4:00 – 5:30 p.m.



Welcome: Why We Are Here

Act 170 calls upon school districts to participate in a structured study of potential regional governance arrangements. This is our first meeting together — a moment to establish a shared foundation before substantive work begins.

Engage Meaningfully

Participate in an informed and evidence-based study of regional governance.

Understand Our Districts

Examine the strengths and challenges of each existing district honestly and completely.

Examine All Implications

Consider educational, operational, financial, and governance impacts together.

Protect Community Voice

Ensure meaningful opportunities for public participation throughout the process.

Build Evidence-Informed Findings

Develop recommendations grounded in facts, not assumptions or predetermined conclusions.

Introductions: Who Is in the Room?

Before we dive into the substance of our work, let's take a few minutes to hear from everyone around the table. Understanding who is here — and what each of us hopes for — helps build the foundation for productive collaboration.

1

Your Name

How you prefer to be addressed during our meetings.

2

Your Role

Board member, administrator, committee designee, or other capacity.

3

Your School or District

Burlington, South Burlington, or Winooski.

4

One Hope

What do you hope for from our time together today and in this process overall?

What Act 170 Requires — and Does Not Require

Understanding the boundaries of our statutory obligations is essential. Act 170 establishes clear requirements — and equally clear limits on what is mandated.

What IS Required

- Participate in good faith throughout the study process.
- Seriously study the advisability of forming a unified union school district.
- Examine educational opportunities, governance, finances, and operational efficiency.
- Complete and submit a final report by **September 1, 2027**.

What Is NOT Required

- Agreement that merger is the best outcome.
- Unanimous support for any proposed governance structure.
- Giving up the ability to advocate strongly for local communities.
- Recommending merger simply because the study is required.

Our Shared Ethos: How We Agree to Work

Effective committee work requires agreed-upon norms. The following commitments are proposed as the foundation for how we engage with one another throughout this process.

Lead with Students

Center educational opportunities, student experiences, access, and long-term outcomes in every conversation.

Challenge Ideas, Not Individuals

Ask difficult questions and test assumptions while maintaining personal respect for all members.

Use Evidence Before Conclusions

Distinguish verified facts from assumptions; seek reliable information before drawing conclusions.

Presume Good Faith

Do not assume that disagreement represents obstruction. Different positions are expected and respected.

Honor Local Voice and Regional Responsibility

Advocate for individual communities while remaining open to considering the broader regional picture.

Share Responsibility for Transparency

Keep our communities informed, follow through on commitments, and maintain open communication.

Understanding Good Faith Participation

The Good Faith Participation Standard focuses on whether the committee can meaningfully complete its required work — not on whether all members agree with one another or with the direction of the study.

Good Faith Generally Includes

- Participating actively in meetings and committee activities.
- Considering information, proposals, and alternatives.
- Providing information necessary for the study.
- Communicating with local boards and communities.
- Following open meeting requirements.

Members May Fully and Freely

- Oppose merger throughout the process.
- Challenge proposals or question the process.
- Criticize assumptions or methodology.
- Advocate strongly for their local communities.

A bad faith determination requires a **documented pattern of conduct** that materially and substantially prevents required committee work — along with notice and an opportunity to address concerns.

Disagreement is not, by itself, bad faith.

Public Posting and Documentation

Vermont's open meeting laws establish non-negotiable requirements for how committee meetings are noticed and documented. These obligations apply to all participating districts and supervisory unions.

1

Regular Meeting Agendas

Posted at least **48 hours** in advance of the meeting.

2

Special Meeting Agendas

Posted at least **24 hours** in advance of the meeting.

3

Draft Meeting Minutes

Posted within **5 calendar days** following the meeting.

4

Recording Links

Posted **as soon as available** after each meeting.

5

Approved Minutes

Posted **as soon as available** following formal approval.

A dedicated Act 170 section on each district website is strongly encouraged. All agendas, minutes, recordings, and committee materials should be centrally accessible to community members.

Committee Leadership and Responsibilities

Three distinct roles carry distinct responsibilities in our committee's work. Understanding these roles helps ensure our meetings are well-organized, productive, and fair to all participants.

Regional Facilitator

- Organizes and facilitates all meetings.
- Frames questions and supports structured discussion.
- Ensures meaningful participation opportunities.
- Coordinates information needs and technical assistance.
- Supports statutory timelines.
- Remains neutral about the final recommendation.

Committee Chair

- Serves as formal presiding officer.
- Recognizes motions and conducts votes.
- Supports orderly meetings and procedural decisions.
- Works with the facilitator on meeting planning and agenda-setting.

Committee Members

- Represent their districts and communities.
- Examine evidence and consider alternatives.
- Participate in deliberations and decisions.
- Communicate findings to their respective school boards.
- Contribute to the final study and recommendation.

Act 170: Key Timeline and Milestones

Our work unfolds within a clear statutory timeline. Understanding these deadlines helps the committee plan its schedule and ensures we complete all required work on time.

1

September 15, 2026

School boards identify representatives for merger committees.

2

October 15, 2026

Statutory deadline for committee formation and first meetings.

3

September 1, 2027

Merger committees complete and submit final reports.

4

December 15, 2027

State Board of Education issues required findings concerning proposed mergers.

5

March 7, 2028

Voters in affected districts consider proposed mergers, where applicable.

6

December 1, 2028

Lead Facilitator submits final legislative report, including findings on good faith participation.

What Will Our Committee Study?

Our study will examine six interconnected areas of inquiry. We begin by developing honest questions — not by defending predetermined conclusions. The goal is a thorough, evidence-based understanding of our region.



Educational Opportunities

How might different governance arrangements affect access to excellent educational experiences for all students?



Student Access and Equity

How would governance configurations affect programs, student supports, and equity of access?



Operational and Financial

What efficiencies, costs, and implementation challenges might arise under different structures?



Governance and Accountability

How might different structures affect transparency, representation, and local community voice?



Career and Technical Education

How would students maintain meaningful access to CTE programs under various arrangements?



Regional Strengths and Challenges

What existing assets, partnerships, and opportunities should inform our regional analysis?

Study Process and Possible Outcomes

The committee's final report is due **September 1, 2027**. Understanding what the report must include — and what outcomes are possible — helps us plan our work effectively from the start.

The Final Report Must Address

- Participating districts and their current structures.
- Strengths and challenges of existing arrangements.
- Educational opportunities and applicable standards.
- Operational efficiency and financial considerations.
- Governance transparency and accountability.
- Career and technical education access.
- Minority views, when the committee is not unanimous.

Possible Outcomes

The committee may determine that forming a unified union school district is:

- **Advisable** — triggering applicable state review and local voter approval processes.
- **Not advisable** — which is a fully legitimate and complete outcome of the study.

Both are valid conclusions. The committee conducts the study. It does not predetermine the voters' decision.

Public Participation and Community Voice

The committee's work must be transparent, accessible, and genuinely open to the communities we represent. Public confidence in this process depends on consistent, clear communication — not just at the end, but throughout our work.

Accessible Notices and Materials

All meeting notices, agendas, and supporting materials made available to community members in advance.

Opportunities for Public Input

Public comment opportunities consistent with meeting procedures and open meeting requirements.

Clear Communication of Decisions

Transparent explanations of what the committee is considering, studying, and deciding at each stage.

Regular School Board Updates

Consistent reporting back to participating school boards throughout the study process.

The Vermont Learning Collaborative maintains a Merger Committee Website Directory at vtlc.org.

Organizing Our Work: Decisions Ahead

01

Elect a Committee Chair

Place on the next meeting agenda; members are encouraged to consider the responsibilities before then.

02

Confirm Meeting Procedures

Agree on rules of order, how motions are made, voting procedures, and minute-taking responsibilities.

03

Establish a Meeting Cadence

Set a predictable, regular meeting schedule and identify accessible meeting locations for the community.

04

Clarify Public Communication Roles

Assign responsibility for agendas, minutes, recordings, website posting, and community updates.

05

Organize the Study

Identify priority questions, data needs, and required technical assistance for our six study areas.

Our First Substantive Study Conversation

Regional Strengths and Assets

What strengths within our communities and across the region should we be proud of?

Educational Programs

What programs and learning opportunities are already strong across Burlington, South Burlington, and Winooski?

Student Supports

What specialized services, intervention programs, and student support structures exist in each district?

CTE Pathways

How are students currently accessing career and technical education, and what partnerships support that access?

Cross-District Collaboration

Where are districts already working together? What existing regional partnerships should inform our analysis?

Closing Reflection and Next Steps

1	**Confirm Next Meeting** Agree on our next meeting date, time, and accessible location before we leave today.
2	**Chair Election on Next Agenda** Place the election of the Committee Chair as a formal agenda item for our next meeting.
3	**Share Resources** Distribute the Good Faith Participation Standard and related Act 170 materials to all members.
4	**Confirm Posting Responsibilities** Clarify who is responsible for each required public posting and documentation task.
5	**Begin Regional Asset Inventory** Start identifying regional strengths, data needs, and questions to guide our substantive study.

Questions or needs between meetings?
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